

AGAINST THE TIDE documents the struggles of Ganesh and Rakesh, two fishermen with diverging paths and beliefs

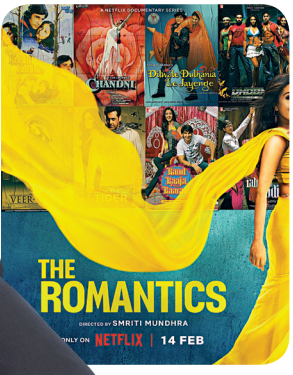
Film Festival—the third successive Indian documentary to do so. Like its predecessors—Rintu Thomas and Sushmit Ghosh's Oscar-nominated *Writing with Fire* (2021) and Shaunak Sen's Oscar-nominated *All That Breathes* (2022)—*Against the Tide* also picked up a Sundance documentary award.

Armed with a conservational spirit and a melancholic eye, Kaur and cinematographer Ashok Meena craft a bleak portrait of the sea, contrasting the effects of climate change with the despair of people who depend on it for their livelihood and identities.

From the very beginning, Kaur was certain that she didn't want to turn *Against the Tide* into an environmental thesis. "I wanted to do a film, which was going to be a series of conversations between two friends." Kaur says. "It's during this process that I sensed that whatever crises are happening at sea are also crises that are happening in their own lives." Kaur ensured she captured that parallel through cinematographer Ashok Meena's camerawork. When they were shooting at sea, the filmmaker strove to underline the "physical and meditative nature" of fishing with wide, roving shots. "I wanted to bring out the romance my characters had with the sea without romanticising their lives." That is amply evident with the suffocation that the audience feels when Kaur charts the mounting financial and familial constraints that Ganesh and Rakesh navigate in terse blocking and over-the-shoulder close-ups.

With a European premiere now on the cards, Kaur describes the critical acclaim that *Against the Tide* garnered at its world premiere as an immensely fulfilling experience. An Oscar nomination might be a long shot down the road, but it's natural to wonder whether the filmmaker feels pressured to match the footsteps of Ghosh, Thomas and Sen. Kaur is quick to reply, describing the momentum that her peers gathered as a privilege, not a burden. "At the moment, I'm brimming with curiosity. The film has brought me so far. Who is to say that someday it won't bring me the moon?" ■

Poulomi Das



heart—the oeuvre touches upon an extra-marital affair (*Silsila*), a love triangle (*Chandni*), falling in love with an older man (*Lamhe*), obsessive love (*Darr*), and love with no strings attached (*Befikre*), to name a few.

For Mundhra, it was essential that the show explores "different iterations of romance" across decades, and gives cinephiles a generous dose of rare anecdotes with a socio-cultural perspective. "Something I learned later in my life is how progressively he [Yash Chopra] portrayed romance and the lack of judgement [he exercised] in different types of relationships," she says. "I don't know anyone who has been able to do it quite the way he did."

It's Chopra's goodwill that helped Mundhra get the who's who of the industry to be a part of her labour of love that took three years to make. From Amitabh Bachchan and the late Rishi Kapoor to the Khans—Aamir, Shah Rukh and Salman—and Madhuri Dixit, among others. "Each of them is a keeper of cinema history," says Mundhra. The net result, as she describes, is a "front-row seat to the evolution of the industry".

But by far the biggest coup here is the interview with the elusive Aditya Chopra, who hasn't given one since 1995. "I give credit to Adi because it can be scary to trust an outsider with your legacy," she says. "But I think he realised it's that very perspective which made it interesting."

The Romantics comes at a time when the YRF banner is basking in the success of its biggest money-spinner in *Pathaan*, a part of its 'Spy Universe'. The studio's last memorable love story was perhaps *Dum Laga Ke Haisha* (2015), which didn't have the pop cultural resonance of *DDLJ* or *Chandni*. It begs the question—is the studio abandoning a genre that gave it name and fame? Says Mundhra, "These things are very cyclical. Market response dictates the need to replicate what's working. All it takes is one film to capture people's hearts and you'll see the trend return." ■

Suhani Singh